Lecture 1 English Language Studies Introduction

Instructor Introduction

- Rashida Abdul Hakim from America.
- In education since 1986.
- Worked with IOU since its inception.

Course Purpose and Goals

- Strengthen academic literacy skills.
- Provide strategies for college success and career success.
- Personal responsibility: Acquire skills, knowledge, values, attitudes for college and workplace.

Topics Covered

- Note taking (essential skill many lack).
- Summary writing.
- Grammar: Parts of speech, punctuation, subject-verb agreement.
- Sentence construction.
- Writing process (steps, not just product).
- Study skills and tips.

Required Textbooks (PDFs)

Textbook	Author
Academic Literacy	J. Underhill & C. Dube
English Grammar for the Utterly Confused	L. Rosakis
Introduction to Academic Writing	Hoshima & A. Hoag

Unit 1 - Learning Outcomes

1. Understand demands of academic study.
2. Identify and apply learning styles.
3. Explain required knowledge, skills, attitudes, values for higher education and workforce.
4. Identify academic tasks/assignments requirements.
5. Discuss academic reading/writing requirements.
6. Explain links between reading, thinking, writing.

Demands of Academic Study

Higher education vs. high school

- Requires independence and self-motivation.
- Broader, intense assignments; multiple sources.
- Limited interaction with instructors, especially online.

Key Skills

- Reading and writing → foundation for all other skills.
- Critical thinking → analyze and sustain/refute arguments.
- Creative thinking → generate novel ideas, invent knowledge.

Student Responsibilities

- Be proactive: Explore needs, monitor progress, reflect on feedback.
- Plan: Units/week, revision schedule; commit, avoid dropout.
- Reward yourself; volunteer (relevant to field, get references for CV).
- Go beyond materials: Use web, videos; develop critical/creative thinking for problem-solving.

Acquiring Knowledge

- Inquiry-minded: Ask what/how/why; apply info (e.g., Quran + tafsir).
- Technology: Lectures, videos (not available in past).
- Creative thinking: Invent novel ideas, innovate

Career & Study Questionnaire

(Refer the book for this - Academic Literacy p.14)

Learning Styles

Learning Style	Description	Method / aids used
Auditory	Learn by hearing	Record lectures/notes, review aloud, mnemonics
Visual	Learn by seeing	flow charts, mind maps, flashcards with images; recall pictures/faces
Kinesthetic	Hands-on	posters, flashcards

Learning Style Questionnaire

(Refer the downloaded material for this)

- My learning style is Visual (mostly) and Auditory

Lecture 2 Developing Vocabulary

Learning Objectives

- Use strategies for determining meaning of unknown words using context clues.
- Use an English dictionary effectively.
- Give definitions of subject-specific terminology.
- Use homophones correctly.
- Identify and use prefixes and suffixes (emphasis on prefixes).

Importance of Vocabulary

- Essential for academic success (assignments, reading subjects).
- Needed in workplace for oral and written communication.
- Builds through consistent reading and dictionary use.

Word Structure Basics (Types of Words)

- Root word: Base word with **no additions** (e.g., photo, clear).
- Prefix: Letters at **beginning** changing meaning (e.g., un + clear = unclear).
- Suffix: Letters at **end** changing meaning (e.g., ly + clear = clearly).

Prefixes

Definition: Letters at the beginning of a word that alter its meaning.

Note - memorise all from Academic Literacy p. 20 - testable

Prefix	Meaning	Examples	Sentence & Meaning
ante	before	antechamber, antenatal	He paused before entering the dark antechamber. → Waiting room

Prefix	Meaning	Examples	Sentence & Meaning
anti	against	anticlockwise, anticoagulant	Hooked up to anticoagulant drip. → Prevents blood clotting
co	with/together	co-supervisor, co-star	Co-star → Someone starring with another
De	remove/take away	deforest, defunct	Organization became defunct. → No longer in use
dis	not/away from	distress, distrust	“He began to distrust his colleagues after the incident.” → not trusting
Ex	out of, away from	excommunicate	After admitting offense, he was excommunicated. → Cut off from community
hyper	very/extremely	hyperactive, hypermarket	Child is hyperactive. → Very active
hypo	under/less	hypothermia, hypocritical	Hypothermia → Condition of low body temperature
in	not/ lacking/ the opposite of	invalid, impolite	Impolite → Not polite “The instructions were indirect.” → not direct
mal	wrong/bad	malfunction	Malfunction → Something not functioning correctly
micro	very small	Microphone, microscope	“He used a microscope to observe the cells.” → small / miniature
mis	not/wrong/badly	misdirect, misconception, misapply, miscalculate	“He miscalculated the total amount.” → calculated incorrectly

Prefix	Meaning	Examples	Sentence & Meaning
mono	one	monograph, monochrome	“The researcher wrote a monograph on bird migration.” → single or one
non	not/none	non-aligned, noncommittal, nonconformist	“The country remained non-aligned in the conflict.” → not aligned
post	after	postgraduate, post-industrial, postmodern	“She enrolled in a postgraduate program.” → after studying/degree
pre	before	prearrange, prenatal, preamble, precaution, precede	“Prenatal care is essential for expecting mothers.” → before birth
pro	for/on behalf of	proactive, procure, profile, profound	“Being proactive at work helps prevent problems.” → acting in advance
re	again	retract, retrain, retreat, retread	“Please repeat the instructions.” → do again
semi	half	semi-automatic, semi-professional, semi-skilled	“He is a semi-professional player.” → partially professional
sub	under/beneath	subnormal, subsection, submission	“Read the subsection on climate change.” → under a larger section
trans-	across, through	transfigure, transform, transfix	“The magician could transform the rabbit into a dove.” → change form
Un	Not	unpleasant, unplayable, unobserved, unofficial	“The weather was unpleasant, so we stayed indoors.” → not pleasant

Exercise – Prefix Usage

1. Tennis umpires often **mispronounce** names.
2. The queen **unveiled** a memorial statue.
3. People who cannot read/write are **illiterate.**
4. Smoking while pregnant is **irresponsible.**
5. Blowing your nose in public is **impolite.**
6. Cyclist was **disqualified** after failing a drugs test.
7. Food that cannot be eaten is **inedible.**
8. Electrical appliance should be **disconnected** from main supply.
9. Wrong theory is **disproved.**
10. Stealing and lying are **dishonest** acts.

Suffixes

Definition: Letters at the end of a word that alter its meaning or add to their meaning. Most importantly, they show how a word will be used in a sentence and which part of speech.

Note that adding a suffix to some root words changes the spelling of the new word.

Note - memorise all from Academic Literacy p. 21 - testable

Suffix	Example	Meaning / Use
-ose / os	adipose	full of / Human body has adipose tissue. → Fatty
-osis	psychosis	process/condition . Patient diagnosed with psychosis. → Mental condition
-ory	dormitory, laboratory	relating to / Places associated with activity
-ous	illustrious, nauseous	full of. Nauseous → Full of nausea
-some	cumbersome, quarrelsome, foursome	characterized by. Foursome → Group of four people
-ed	walk + ed = walked	past tense

Suffix	Example	Meaning / Use
-ing	say + ing = saying	present participle / continuous tense
-er	small + er = smaller	comparative
-est	tall + est = tallest	superlative
-tion	educate + tion = education	action / process
-sion	revise + sion = revision	action / process
-fully	care + fully = carefully	manner / way
-ness	happy + ness = happiness	state / quality
-al	accident + al = accidental	relating to
-ary	imagine + ary = imaginary	relating to / connected with
-able	accept + able = acceptable	capable of / able to
-ly	love + ly = lovely	characteristic of / manner
-ment	fulfil + ment = fulfilment	result / process
-ful	mind + ful = mindful	full of / characterized by
-y	ease + y = easy	characterized by / having the quality of

Compound words

There are three forms of compound words:

1. **The closed form** - words are blended together - afternoon, football backup, airport, chalkboard, classmate, daydream, fingernail.
2. **The hyphenated form** - word-of-mouth, nitty-gritty, know-it-all, mother-in-law, well-being, three-dimensional.
3. **The open form** - post office, real estate, course work, cash flow, energy bar, memory stick, new world.

Examples with meaning -

Compound word	**Meaning**
Limestone	Sedimentary rock.
Pacemaker	Heart device.
Underachieve	Perform below potential.

Compound word	Meaning
Superego	Conscience part.
Waterline	Water border on floating body.
Blueprint	Detailed plan.
Foreclosure	Mortgage seizure.

Homophones

Homophones: Same sound, different spelling/meaning (e.g., to/too/two).

Common Confusing Pairs

1. Accept/except
2. It's/its
3. Affect/effect
4. Elicit/illicit
5. Principal/principle
6. Stationary/stationery
7. Than/then
8. Threw/through
9. Passed/past

Context Clues Strategies

Guess unknown words before dictionary; use chart:

Word	Guess	Dictionary Definition	Sentence.
Blue Print	Plan or layout of something	a photographic plan or a description of how to make, build or achieve something	"The architect showed us the blueprint of the new school building."

- **Definition**: Restates word (e.g., "homogeneous… uniform characteristics" → same).
- **Synonym**: Similar word (e.g., "exalted… overjoyed" → very happy).
- **Antonym**: Opposite (e.g., "tentative… willing" → uncertain).
- **Description**: Explains traits (e.g., "unyielding… inflexible" → rigid).
- **Summary**: Lists examples (e.g., "impertinent… rudely, no respect" → rude).

Lecture 3 Reading for Studying Purposes

Importance of Reading and Writing

Reading & writing are critical for success in: University studies, Workplace, Daily life (e.g., reading labels, instructions)

Academic focus: Reading improves understanding of subjects and the world; enhances writing skills.

Interconnection: More reading → better writing; more writing → better reading.

Types of Academic Texts

- **Textbooks / PDFs** – detailed study resources.
- **Journal articles** – shorter, research-based articles written by experts.

Structure of Academic Texts:

Thesis (main argument)

- Usually found in the introduction.
- The rest of the text supports this main argument.
- Identifying the thesis prepares you for the supporting arguments.

Topic sentence

- A sentence that carries the main idea of each paragraph.
- Often the first sentence (but not always).
- Helps you:
  - Underline the main idea of the paragraph.
  - Summarize the text quickly

Journal article structure

Professional academic journal articles usually include:

Component	Purpose
Abstract	Brief summary of research, methods, findings, significance
Introduction	Background: previous research, why the study is needed, and what the researcher hopes to achieve.
Method	How the research was done: procedures, data collection, and analysis

Component	Purpose
Results	What the study found (data and findings)
Discussion	Interpretation of the results and their implications.
Conclusion	Main meaning, implications, and suggestions for changes or further research

Why do we read?

Main reasons for reading:

- Relaxation (for enjoyment).
- Find specific information (e.g., numbers, facts, definitions).
- Get an overview of a text (main ideas).
- Critically analyze the text (writer's style, purpose, and message).
- Study purposes (for exams, assignments, understanding concepts)

Reading Strategies

Scanning

Purpose: Find specific facts or phrases quickly.
Technique: Rapid eye movement, looking for keywords or numbers.
Examples:

- Searching a dictionary or directory
- Checking program times or prices
- Answering specific questions in a text

Skimming

Purpose: Get a general overview of the text.
Technique: Rapid eye movement, reading titles, subtitles, first/last sentences, illustrations, table of contents, index.
Examples:

- Browsing newspapers, catalogs, websites
- Deciding whether to read a book or article

Difference between scanning and skimming:

Strategy	Focus	Technique	Used in
Scanning	Specific info	Rapid search for facts/keywords	Exams, directories, recipes
Skimming	General overview	Rapid glance at headings, illustrations, first/last sentences	Newspapers, catalogs, browsing books

Example Exercises
Skimming: Look at title, picture, subtitle of "Cat Up a Tree, Chimp in a Chimney."
Scanning: Answer recipe questions without reading the full text.

SQ3R Method

S = Survey → Skim headings, subheadings, illustrations, first/last paragraphs, discussion questions.
Q = Question → Turn headings/subheadings into questions; create questions from illustrations or graphics.
Write questions: In the margins of the textbook or printed PDF or in a separate notebook.
R = Read → Active reading; interact with text. Read section by section, looking for answers to the questions you formulated. Annotate using symbols:

a. * → important point
b. ? → question
c. ! → strong reaction
d. Highlight main points, vocabulary, definitions.

R = Recite → Test understanding: Repeat main points aloud. Take brief notes (no complete sentences)
R = Review → Check notes for accuracy; ensure understanding. Review regularly (not just before exams)

Lecture 4 Annotating Text

Identify and highlight critical information only when annotating text.
Avoid underlining/highlighting everything—focus on important points for easy review.

Annotation Strategy

Step 1: Read silently (full comprehension).
Step 2: Read aloud (better retention).
Step 3: Annotate (highlight key phrases, add questions/notes).
Read 3x total; schedule time despite busyness.
Use highlighters, underlines, bold, or PDF comments/sticky notes.
Side notes: Use fragments/abbreviations (e.g., "4-5 pts" not full sentences) for quick review.
Questions: Note briefly (e.g., "meaning?") for professor/forum.

Examples used	Reference the book	Pg no	
Management Text	Academic Literacy	36	
Traditional Hindu Wedding	Intro to Academic Writing	29	
Havasu Canyon	Intro to Academic Writing	52	
Woman's Wali	Quest for Love and Mercy	Ch.4, p.64	

Lecture 5 Note Taking

Importance of Note Taking

Note taking = selecting key information + writing briefly
Helps in:

- Understanding
- Remembering
- Studying efficiently

Goal of Good Notes

- Concise (short)
- Clear
- Organized
- Easy to revise

-

Features of Effective Notes

- DO NOT write sentences Use:
- Use Structure - Title , Subheadings, Bullet points, numbers
- Be Brief
- Use Your Own Words - Do not copy text. Simplify ideas
- Use Abbreviations
- Use Symbols
- Use Sub-points - Main idea → bullet, Details → sub-bullets

Tips:

- Go beyond highlighting: Rewrite in notebook/Word (internalizes info)
- Recite aloud (like SQ3R method) for retention

Poor Notes ❌	Good Notes ✅
Full sentences	Keywords only
Long & messy	Short & neat
Hard to study	Easy to revise
Looks like textbook	Organized format

Note-Taking Process

Step 1: Identify Important Points

- Main ideas
- Key facts
- Repeated concepts

Step 2: Convert to Notes

- Remove unnecessary words
- Shorten phrases
- Use bullets

Step 3: Organize

- Add:
  - Title

- Subtopics
- ndentation

Practice Example 1: Study Time

Title: Finding Study Time

Creative thinking

- commute → study time
- waiting (airport/train)
- ready meals
- ↓ TV/social time

Weekly timetable

- plan study time
- involve family
- balance needs

Sleep

- gradual ↓ sleep
- find ideal balance
- too little → irritability

Relaxation

- include breaks
- hobbies/sports
- Favorite things

Practice Example 2: Traditional Hindu Wedding

Refer book for this - Intro to Academic Writing, p.29

Practice Example 3: Havasu Canyon

Refer book for this - Intro to Academic Writing, p.52

Practice 4: Woman's Wali

Refer book for this - Quest for Love and Mercy, Ch.4, p.64/89)

Lecture 6 Note-Taking Skills

Objectives

Identify important information in text.
Take concise notes for oral presentations.
Prepare notes for oral presentations

Note Taking Process

1. Read the Text

- First reading → Silent
- Second reading → Aloud
- Understand overall meaning

2. Highlight Important Points

- Focus only on:
  - Main ideas
  - Key details
  - Avoid highlighting everything

3. Convert into Notes

- Use:
  - Short phrases
  - Keywords
  - No full sentences

Example 1: River Rafting

Refer book for this - Intro to Academic Writing, p.68

Key Message: Challenging sport with important requirements.
Company: Good safety record.

- Levels: I (no experience) to VI (most experienced).
- Level I: River slow; few rocks/boulders; enjoy scenery.

Upper levels: Increasing powerful waves, dangerous rocks.

- High river: Fast current, rough ride (experienced only).

• Special Equipment: Inflatable rubber boat; life jacket, helmet, paddle.
• Group: 6-8 people + trained guide.

Alertness: Obey guide instructions instantly; teamwork to avoid disaster.

Risks: High chance of falling overboard; pull back aboard.

Ideal Candidate: Courageous, experienced, good physical condition, quick reactions.

Tips: Use thesaurus.com for synonyms (e.g., "stringent" for important). Revise for clarity. Practice oral presentation (record self). Avoid - Long paragraphs, same author words, over-highlighting.

Example 2: Mountain Climbin

Refer book for this - Intro to Academic Writing, p. 74

Key Message: Dangerous sport; special requirements + strict rules.

I. Requirements

- Complete course in certified climbing school (learn conditions, safe climbing).
- Special clothing: Season-appropriate; helmet, climbing boots.
- Carry equipment: Iron spikes, climbing ropes.

II. Rules

- Climb alone or teams (2+); tied at waist to same rope (protect slips).
- One foothold/handhold at a time.
- Give exact commands/responses to partners.
- Aware of falling rocks/boulders.
- Rest on ledge when tired.

III. Rewards

Beautiful views: Treetops, rivers, lakes, distant mountains, moving clouds.

Example 3: Animals in Captivity

Refer book for this - Intro to Academic Writing, p. 88

Advantages	Disadvantages
Protected from predators (no attacks).	Become bored, discontented, nervous (no hunting/enemies).
Regularly fed well-balanced diet (no hunting/starvation).	Visitors endanger: Airborne diseases from humans.
Vet checkups + prompt medical attention (healthy/contented).	Visitors throw human food/garbage → illness/death

Lecture 7 Mind Mapping

Introduction to Mind Mapping

- **Focus:** Mind mapping for effective note-taking
- **Goal:** Learn to use mind maps by session end
- **Tony Buzan:** Inventor of mind mapping (best-selling author, expert in creativity, learning, memory)

What is a Mind Map?

- A visual note-taking method
- Starts with a central idea
- Expands into branches (subtopics)
- Shows:
  - Relationships
  - Hierarchy of ideas

Key Features of Mind Maps

1. Central Image
   - Placed in the middle of the page
   - Represents the main topic
   - Why?
     - Stimulates memory
     - Triggers associations
     - Encourages thinking

2. Branches
   - Radiate from the center
   - Curved (not straight)
   - **Represent:**
     - Main ideas (BOIs – Basic Ordering Ideas)
     - Subtopics → further branches

3. Hierarchical Structure
   - Levels:
     - Main branches → sub-branches → deeper ideas
   - Reflects natural thinking process
   - Can expand infinitely

4. <u>One Keyword per Branch</u>
    - Use single words only
    - Avoid: Sentences and long phrases
    - Reason:
        - Each word = “idea trigger”
        - Encourages more associations & creativity

5. <u>Use of Color & Images</u>
    - Colors help
        - Organize
        - Highlight
        - Remember
    - Images improve:
        - Memory
        - Interest
        - Understanding

Feature	Mind Map (Tony Buzan)	Mapping (General)
Structure	Central image + branches	Circles / boxes
Keywords	Single word only	Words or phrases
Style	Creative, colorful	More flexible
Use	Idea generation	Summary/overview

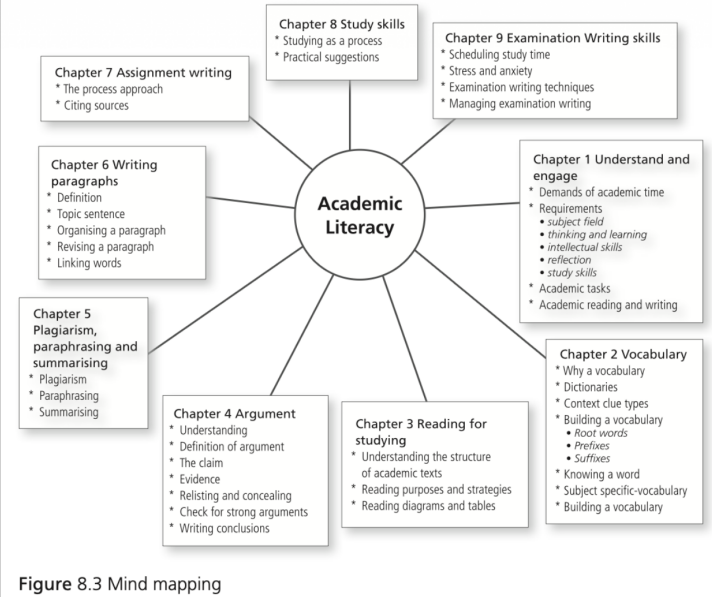


Figure 8.3 Mind mapping

Practice: Training Managers

Refer book for this - Intro to academic writing p.36

Central: Training Manager

- Branches:
  - Only practicing managers
  - Sponsored by companies
  - Participants: 4-5; strong intellectual abilities; proven record
  - Length: 2 weeks; 5 on-site modules; 16 months total

Practice: Traditional Hindu Wedding

Refer book for this - Intro to academic writing p.29

Central: Traditional Hindu Wedding

- Main branches:
  - Lavish
  - Preparations:
    - **Timing** - months before | **details** - groom- Jewelry, gifts for bride's family, bride clothes, mangalsutra (bless thread) Bride's family: Groom clothes, dowry
    - Timing - night before | **details** - Henna (green/red)
  - Ceremony:
    - Groom to bride's house w/ gifts
    - Groom: Wears headdress, garlands flowers; arrives white car/horse/ elephant
    - Sit around sacred fire under canopy; priest chants prayers
    - Bride dress tied to groom scarf
    - Walk around fire 7 times; groom 7 promises
  - After: Musicians, traditional games; ends after midnight

Practice: River Rafting

Refer book for this - intro to academic writing p.68
Central: River Rafting (challenging sport

- Main branches:
  - Company: Good safety record
  - Levels (1-6)
    - level 1 - River slow; few rocks/boulders; enjoy scenery
    - upper levels - Strong waves; dangerous rocks

- Special equipment:
    - Inflatable rubber boat, life jacket, helmet, paddle
- Requirements:
    - Guide (shout instructions); 6-8 people; be alert; ability to use paddle

Tips for Mapping

1. Abbreviate (e.g., fam, cl, prom) for memory/space
2. No right/wrong; use colors/images for recall
3. Tools: Paint, online templates, software
4. Uses: Study guide, presentations, pre-writing
5. Recommendation: Try for all subjects; experiment styles per course

---

Lecture 8 Outline of Note Taking

Learn how to take notes using outline format
Understand structure, rules, and usage

What is an Outline?

- A structured way of organizing notes
- Uses hierarchical levels:
    - **Roman numerals** (I, II, III) → Main ideas
    - **Capital letters** (A, B, C) → Subpoints
    - **Numbers** (1, 2, 3) → Details
    - **Small letters** (a, b) → Further details

Important Rules

- No “I” without “II”
- No “A” without “B”
- Maintain parallel structure
- Alignment: A/B/C under first letter of Roman numeral word; numbers under A.
- Brevity: 1-3 words/phrases (avoid sentences unless sentence outline).
- Capitalize first word only.
- Indent properly; leave space for additions.

Example 1: Mountain Climbing

Refer book for this - intro to academic writing p.74

Mountain Climbing

I. Requirements

- A. Complete certified course
- B. Wear special clothing
    1. Helmet
    2. Climbing boots
- C. Carry equipment
    1. Iron spikes
    2. Climbing ropes

II. Rules

- A. Climb alone
- B. Climb with team
    1. Two or more
    2. Tied to waist
    3. Give commands/responses

III. Dangers

- A. Falling rocks
- B. Boulders

IV. Rewards

- A. Beautiful view
    1. Treetops
    2. Rivers
    3. Lakes
    4. Mountains
    5. Moving clouds

Example 2: Islamic Marriage Contract

Refer book - Quest for Love and Mercy, p. 81

Islamic Marriage Contract Elements

I. Conditions (6 total; dropping invalidates contract)

A. Bridegroom's eligibility
B. Bride's eligibility
C. Bridegroom's consent
D. Bride's consent
E. Wali's approval
F. Two witnesses

II. Pillars (2 total)
A. Offer/proposal (woman in marriage)
B. Acceptance

III. Obligation - 1; dropping is sin)
A. Dowry

IV. Optional Element
A. Imposed conditions

Example 3: Woman's Wali

Refer book - Quest for Love and Mercy, p. 89/64,

Ruling on Woman's Wali

I. Ruling
A. Woman can't give self in marriage
B. Wali represents her
C. Virgin consent needed

II. Who is Wali?
A. Father
B. Death of father: grandfather, son, brother, uncle
C. New Muslim woman (no Muslim relatives)
1. Can't take woman as wali
2. Judge (Muslim country) or Imam (non-Muslim country)

III. Can't Appoint Own Wali (non-Muslim countries)
A. Untrustworthy wali: unqualified, incapable
B. Laxity: intimate friend, khalwa (major sins)
C. High expectations: many duties beyond marriage

Example 4: Animals in Captivity

Refer book for this - intro to academic writing p.88

Animals in Captivity

I. Advantages
   A. Protected from predators
   B. Well-balanced diet
   C. Regular checkups
   D. Immediate medical attention

II. II. Disadvantages
   A. Feelings: bored, discontented, nervous
   B. Dangerous visitors
   C. Diseases from humans
   D. Visitors feed garbage
      1. Become seriously ill
      2. Die

Example 5: Training Managers

Refer book for this - academic literacy p.36

Training Managers

I. Participants (4-5 total)
   A. Practicing managers only
   B. Sponsored by company
   C. Not intelligence/test scores
   D. Strong abilities + proven record

II. Duration
   A. Two weeks
   B. Five on-site modules
   C. Over 16 months

III. Other Activities

Example 6: Traditional Hindu Wedding

Refer book for this - intro to academic writing p.29

Traditional Hindu Wedding

I. Lavish

II. Preparations
    A. Several months before
        1. Groom's family
            a. Jewelry/gifts
            b. Mangalsutra (blessed necklace)
            c. Red/gold dress
        2. Bride's family: clothes for groom, dowry
    B. Night before:
        1. henna

III. Day of Ceremony
    A. many subcategories

IV. After Wedding:
    A. Bride leaves with husband

Lecture 9 Understanding Academic Arguments

Learning Objectives

- Explain importance of understanding academic arguments.
- Analyze main claims in sample arguments.
- Identify supporting evidence.
- Make judgments about evidence quality.
- Distinguish between arguments.

What is an Argument?

An argument = presenting a viewpoint (claim) + strong evidence

Goal:

- Convince the reader/audience
- Even when there is a counter argument

Key elements:

- Evidence is critical.
- Consider the audience.
- Refute counterarguments.

Importance of Academic Arguments

- Encourages logical thinking (not emotional/bias)
- Helps analyze conflicting ideas
- Discerns and refutes contradictory claims.
- Builds clear and reliable communication
- State thoughts clearly, correctly, reliably
- Promotes respectful consideration of others' views
- Develops ability to:
  - Form opinions on evidence quality and investigation methods.
  - Evaluate evidence
  - Refute weak arguments

Example: Argue smoking is haram with Quran, Hadith, analogies (e.g., alcohol harm).

Reading Academic Arguments (Strategy)

What to Do

- Highlight main points
- Interact with the text
  - Write notes / comments
- Note counter arguments while reading

Questions to Ask

- What is the author trying to prove? Or convincing me of?
- Does author assume agreement?
- Do I agree/disagree? Why?
- Is there enough evidence?
- What type of evidence is used?
- Is anything missing?

Structure & Components of Arguments

Main claim

Clear viewpoint - Must be:

- Debatable
- Not obvious
- Not purely opinion

Strong Claim = Clear + specific + arguable

Claim Qualities

- Debatable/controversial (e.g., smoking is haram vs. consensus like alcohol is haram).
- Not self-evident (e.g., men can't have babies).
- Not just opinion (e.g., "women prefer staying home").
- Clear/precise in introduction (avoid vague like "some people cause trouble").

Evidence

Supports the claim using:

- Facts (provable)
- Statistics
- Examples
- Expert opinions
- Definitions

Always:

- Use multiple pieces of evidence
- Ensure sources are reliable
- Avoid Wikipedia

Type	Description	Uses
Hard Evidence	Facts, statistics, research	academic writing
Soft Evidence	Emotion, personal experience	Informal Use

Characteristics of Strong Evidence

- Sufficient (not too little)
- Relevant and applicable
- Current
- Verifiable (with sources/footnotes)

- Reliable authority
- Well-researched
- Connected logically.

Fact vs Opinion

- Fact → can be proven
- Opinion → belief/feeling
- Academic writing → focus on facts + expert opinions

Analyzing an Argument

Ask:

- What is the main claim?
- Is the evidence relevant?
- Are counter arguments included?
- Is there bias or emotional language or personal opinion?
- Is the argument logical and complete?
- Sense of finality/closure?

Handling Counterarguments

- Anticipate opposition.
- Analyze their evidence; provide refutation.

Example 1: Social networking sites detrimental to relationships

Refer book for this - academic literacy p.68

Pros	Cons
Fast info sharing (life-saving).	Spreads false info.
Helps law enforcement catch criminals.	Used for illegal activities (stats needed).
Job finding (e.g., LinkedIn).	Harms jobs via exposed info. / privacy risks
Stays in touch, helps shy/isolated.	Reduces face-to-face; ends friendships.
Educational tool for teachers/students.	Causes depression, low self-esteem; distracts students; promotes cheating.

Use this to:

- Compare arguments
- Identify stronger side
- Highlight opponent weaknesses.

Sample Analysis: "Single Parent Struggle"

- **Main claim**: Raising kids depends on process/values, not family structure; single-parent kids can develop equally well.
- **Support**: Stats (58% US kids in single-parent homes), personal experience (male role models from family), refutes counter (e.g., juvenile crime link absurd).
- **Counters addressed:** Need for both parents? Role models? Step-parents cause stress.
- **Strengths:** Some stats, contrasts (but/however).
- **Weaknesses:** Missing stats in spots; vague "benefits"; emotional bits.
- **Avoid in strong arguments:** Excess emotion, generalizations, assumptions, poor word choice (all/always vs. some/often).

Pointers for Strong Arguments (p.53)

Use logic/reason.

Rely on facts/evidence (avoid excess emotion).

Self-check questions:

1. Evidence supports conclusions?
2. All evidence considered (incl. opposition)?
3. Avoid questionable generalizations?
4. Plain, correct language?
5. No emotional/subjective bias?
6. No ad hominem (attack people/groups)?
7. Analogies convincing?
8. Not "good because popular"?
9. Link introduction & conclusion (repeat key words/claim).

Exercise on page no:55 of academic literacy

Statement	Claim	Reason
Money is the root of all evil	No	Opinion

Statement	Claim	Reason
A medium-sized business is one that employs up to 200 people and has a turnover of between R5 million and R64 million.	no	Just a fact; no debatable
In these modern times, widespread corruption has an impact economically as well as politically.	Yes	Debatable; narrow + examples/stats.
Barack Hussein Obama II (born 4 August 1961) was the 44th president of the United States. He was the first African-American to hold the office.	No	Fact; no counter.
There is too much bureaucratic red tape in this world for the average citizen to feel free.	Maybe	Broad; narrow it.
The government should reduce interest rates; otherwise people's ability to spend will be constrained.	Yes	Debatable policy.
Nothing is better than the freedom of working your own hours.	No	Opinion (vague)

Lecture 10 Plagiarism

What is Plagiarism?

Definition: Plagiarism = using someone else's work as your own, intentionally or unintentionally.

Includes:

- Copying word-for-word, without quotation marks or citations (parentheses or footnotes).
- Using ideas without credit
- Can be intentional or unintentional

1. **Intentional plagiarism**: Copying bits from multiple sources (e.g., tabs open) without rephrasing.
2. **Unintentional plagiarism:** Poor note-taking, like copying full sentences instead of summarizing briefly.
3. **Mosaic / patchwork:** Copying a little from here, a little from there — mixing sources without proper citation or rewording
4. **Poor paraphrasing:** Changing only a few words or swapping synonyms while keeping the same structure — still counts as plagiarism
5. **Uncited borrowed phrases:** Lifting a recognizable phrase or keyword from a source without quotation marks, even if the rest is reworded
6. **Omission without ellipsis:** Leaving out words from a direct quote without using "..." to show something was removed — misrepresents the source

Penalties for Plagiarism

In university: Teacher may fail the assignment, fail the course, or report to dean leading to expulsion.
Considered academic stealing; professors detect via writing style mismatch or plagiarism software.
Islamic view: "Whoever deceives us is not of us" — cheating is haram

Plagiarism Detection Software

- **Flag Tracker:** Upload paper; scans and reports plagiarized passages.
- **Plagiarisma:** Free; submit up to 2,000 words; email report with % originality.
- **Turnitin**: Paid; professors use for originality checks.
- **Grammarly:** Paid; checks plagiarism + grammar/spelling.

Why Do Students Plagiarize?

1. Fear their writing isn't good enough
2. Procrastination — left it too late
3. Bad note-taking (copying sentences instead of summarizing)
4. Don't know what counts as plagiarism

5. Don't know how to cite sources

How to Avoid Plagiarism

- Best prevention: Take notes in own words (no author wording)
- Take brief notes in your own words — no full sentence
- Close the source — never look at it while writing
- Write your paper from notes only
- Manage Time - Start early, Work little by little
- Cite everything — parentheses (title + page no.) or footnote
- Use Quotation Marks - If copying exact words: Use " " Add source

What is Paraphrasing ?

Restating an idea in your own words without changing the meaning and without using the same wording or structure

Not just swapping synonyms — structure must change too.

Good	Bad
Only synonyms used, same structure	Completely reworded + same meaning
Copying phrases without quote	Different structure + concise

Paraphrase Examples

Original	Paraphrase
Her life spanned years of incredible change for women as they gained more rights than ever before.	She lived through the exciting era of women's liberation.
Giraffes like acacia leaves and hay, and they can consume 75 pounds of food a day.	A giraffe can eat up to 75 pounds of acacia leaves and hay daily.
Any trip to Italy should include a visit to Tuscany to sample the region's economy exquisite wines.	Be sure to make time for a Tuscan wine tasting when visiting Italy.
Symptoms of influenza include fever and nasal congestion.	A stuffy nose and elevated temperature are signs you may have the flu.

Original	Paraphrase
The price of resort vacation typically includes meals, tips, and equipment rentals, which makes your trip more cost effective.	All-inclusive resort vacations can make for an economical trip.
He has tons of stuff to throw away.	He needs to get rid of a lot of junk. Note: "He has a lot of things to throw away" is NOT acceptable — too close to the original.

Important note:
Statistics must be kept accurate in paraphrases. "75 pounds" cannot be changed. What you change is the structure and wording around the number.Statistics must be kept accurate in paraphrases. "75 pounds" cannot be changed. What you change is the structure and wording around the number.

Self - Practice: Writing from Notes from Mountain Climbing and Havasu Canyon

---

Lecture 11 Writing Process

Writing process involves five key steps for organized, clear writing. Skipping steps leads to poor quality; instructors can detect it. Follow all steps over days, not one sitting, for best results transcript.

Step 1: Prewriting (planning/brainstorming)

Prewriting (aka planning or brainstorming) is the most important and often skipped step.

- Jot ideas, words, phrases—not sentences; organize with lists, bullets, numbers, outlines, mind maps, or questions.
- For research, take brief notes; allow days to add ideas via sticky notes or docs transcript.
- Use words/phrases (NOT full sentences)
- Can take several days, keep adding ideas over time

Step 2: Drafting (Writing First Draft)

Write rough draft with sentences and paragraphs using prewriting as guide.

- Create distraction-free environment: no phones, family interruptions, spell-checking, or sources (to avoid plagiarism).
- Double-space or skip lines for later changes; know audience and purpose; let ideas flow without revising transcript.
- Don't worry about -
    - Grammar
    - Spelling
    - Perfection

Step 3: Revising (Content Focus)

- Focus on content: organization, flow, thesis, topic sentences, transitions, intro/body/conclusion.
- Add/delete ideas; address who/what/where/when/how; read aloud or use peers; check length, examples, tone, rubric.

Revision takes longer than drafting—e.g., author Cornelia Funk does 5 drafts, revises every sentence transcript.

- Questions to Ask:
    - Did I answer the question?
    - Is anything missing?
    - Is the structure clear?
    - Are ideas connected?

Step 4: Editing (Technical Accuracy)

- Focus on mechanics: spelling, grammar, punctuation, sentence fragments, verb tenses, active verbs.
- Vary vocabulary/sentence length; remove weak words (e.g., "somewhat"); use dictionary/thesaurus; ensure smooth transitions, no slang.

Read aloud; review commas/punctuation rules; check rubric transcript.

Step 5: Publishing (Final Draft)

- Produce final draft: neat, complete, ready to submit.
- Get peer feedback at multiple stages (questions, not corrections) for revision/editing; final read-through before turning in.
- Conference like in workshops: guide self-identification of issues transcript.

Summary Table

Step	Focus	Key Action
Prewriting	Ideas	Brainstorm & plan
Drafting	Expression	Write freely
Revising	Content	Improve ideas & structure
Editing	Accuracy	Fix grammar & errors
Publishing	Final draft	Submit clean draft

Time Management in Writing

- Writing is not done in one day
- Spread steps over days/weeks

Suggested Approach:

- Start early (within 1 week)
- Divide time:
    - Prewriting → few days
    - Drafting → few days
    - Revising → few days
    - Editing → few days

Note: Prewriting = most neglected but most important step. Good writing = multiple drafts + revisions

Key Tips & Warnings

1. **Start early** (e.g., week 1 of semester); spread steps over days.
2. **Plan** most neglected but crucial—structure intro/body/conclusion purposes. (Writing = Plan → Draft → Revise → Edit → Publish)
3. **Don't rush:** Professional writers take months; multiple drafts normal.
4. **Avoid:** Writing/revising simultaneously, source-gazing during draft, perfectionism transcript.

Lecture 12 Pre-writing in the Writing Process

What is Pre-Writing?

Pre-writing = First step of the writing process
Also called: Planning; Brainstorming

Definition - Getting ideas on paper before writing sentences

Why Pre-writing is Important

- Foundation of writing, like a pillar to a building
- Prevents collapse of ideas; many skip it and jump to sentences (big mistake)

Pre-writing Formats

- Bulleted list (no order, just jot ideas)
- Mind map (topic in center, branches for subtopics)
- Outline (structured with Roman numerals, letters, numbers)
- Question format (WH questions: who, what, where, when, how)

Rules for Outlines:

- Roman numeral I needs II
- Capital A needs B
- Numbers (1, 2) under letters; lowercase a, b under numbers
- Capitalize first word of each entry

Practice Activity 1: Sport/Activity

Refer book - Intro to Academic Writing p. 67

Jot facts using questions:

Question	Example Ideas (Martial Arts)
Types/experience	Muay Thai, Taekwondo, Shotokan, Wing Chun
Description	Fun, keeps healthy, great exercise
Where	Dojo, gym, instructor's home
People needed	1-on-1 with private female instructor
Equipment	Boxing gloves, hand wraps

Question	Example Ideas (Martial Arts)
When started	Muay Thai long ago; recent: 2 years ago
Frequency	Once a month
Effects	Mentally exciting, physically in shape
Recommend why	Keeps healthy, boosts self-feeling, an art to perfect

Practice Activity 2: Why Mothers are Important (topic given by the teacher)

Brainstorm List (short example):

- Intro: Every day is Mother's Day (not just one day; not Islamic focus)
- Raise future leaders
- Best teachers
- Carried us 9 months, bore in pain, nurtured
- Always reliable; often best friends

Revise Pre-writing:

- Add details, organize (e.g., number 1, 2 for paragraphs)
- No full sentences yet

Practice Activity 3: Describe Childhood Home (given by the teacher)

Brainstorm Example

- Location: City (Chennai) state (Tamil Nadu)
- Type: Row house (attached, like townhouses); 3 floors; every floor was an individual house, lived with my cousin(s) and their family as well
  Exterior: yellowish beige; black gate; no garden
- Duration: Since infant to age 24 (till marriage)
- Memories: Played in the terrace (cricket, soccer, Hide & seek, badminton);

Organize for Paragraphs:

- Para 1: Location + duration
- Para 2: Description (type, floors, rooms, exterior)
- Para 3: Memories + feelings (dear to heart)

Outline Example: Childhood Home

MY CHILDHOOD HOME

I. Location
   A. City: Chennai
   B. State: Tamil Nadu

II. Description
    A. Row house (attached; like townhouses)
    B. 3 floors
        1. Second floor - Bedrooms (3), bathrooms (2)
        2. First floor - Bedrooms (2) + Individual room (1), Bathrooms (3)
        3. Ground floor - 2 bedrooms + one guest room bathrooms (3)
    C. Exterior: Gray/white, garden
III. Length of Stay
    A. From infanthood
    B. Till marriage (age 24)
IV. Memories
    A. Played outside
        1. Front: Steps (sometimes sat)
        2. Terrace : Sports/games (cricket, soccer, badminton, hide and seek)
    B. Precious memories

Outline Example: Death in Islam

Death in Islam

I. Introduction
    A. Reality of death
    B. Unknown: where, when, how
II. Purpose of This Life
    A. Temporary test/trials
    B. Worship Allah (no partners)
    C. 3 slips: Womb, death, final destination (not this world)
    D. We are travelers
III. Funeral Preparations (washing, shrouding, Janazah prayer)
IV. Realities of Grave - Bliss or punishment

Tip: Brainstorm first (over days), then outline

Mind Map Examples

- Structure: Topic center → branches (subtopics) → details
- Migrant Mother: Branches: Hand on cheek (thinking), head up, eyes focused, poor (1936)
- Last Wedding: Center Last Wedding → Where (masjid, UK), When (Feb 2016, evening), How (Uber, flight), What (food), Who (daughter, family)

Why Not Watch TV (argument map):

- Benefits + Refutations (red):
- News → Crime reports; read online/YouTube
- Educational (Nat Geo, kids shows) → On YouTube (controlled)
- Drawbacks: Addictive (waste time, neglect prayers), negative influence (copycat crimes), haram to see (Quran/Sunnah evidence)

Lecture 13 Pre-Writing (Application to Assignments)

Pre-writing is the first and most important step in the writing process for academic assignments.

Pre-Writing Steps

Step 1: Understand the Assignment

- Carefully Read Instructions
- Identify:
    - Topic
    - Task type (analysis, comparison, etc.)
    - Length (e.g., 5 pages)
    - Requirements (interviews, sources)
- Check Additional Guidelines
    - Rubric → what is expected
    - Keywords in question → guide your focus

Step 2: Brainstorm Ideas (First Pre-Writing Stage)

- What to Do
    - Write all possible ideas
    - No need for perfection

Example Topics - Community Literacy Project

- Literacy as:
    - Reading & writing
    - Computer literacy
    - Language learning

Sample Brainstorm Questions

1. How common is the practice?
2. Which types are most common?
3. What are the goals/purposes?
4. What are people's feelings/experiences?
5. How proficient do people become?

Step 3: Use Google to Expand Ideas

- Purpose
    - Generate more ideas
    - Find reliable sources
- Important Rule
    - Use professional/academic sources
- Avoid:
    - Random websites
    - Wikipedia (often not accepted)

Step 4: Collect & List Sources

- What to Do
    - Copy - Links, Article titles
- Tip - Aim for: 5–10 sources (for a 5-page paper). You may - Use some and discard others later

Step 5: Take Notes (Second Pre-Writing Stage)

- Key Rules for Notes, keep them:
    - Short
    - Organized
    - Topic-based
- Old but Effective Method
    - Use index cards
    - One topic per card
    - Categorize ideas

Step 6: Create an Outline (Final Pre-Writing Stage)

- From notes; prefer outline format (may submit with assignment).

Stage	What you do
1	Understand assignment
2	Brainstorm ideas
3	Google topic
4	List sources
5	Take notes
6	Create outline

Pre-writing occurs in three phases

1. List of ideas
2. Notes from sources
3. Outline

Example 1: Community Literacy Project

Assignment: 5-page paper on literacy practice unique to a community (yours preferred); conduct 2-3 interviews (voice/email/video); compare experiences; argue evolution with data/sources.

Key Requirements

- Expanded literacy definition: Beyond reading/writing (e.g., language learning, computer use).
- Cautions: Be respectful; get written permission; avoid harm.
- Primary Share with instructor.

Brainstorm for South Africa (assumed community)

- Foreign language acquisition (chosen topic; narrowed to schools).
- **Ideas:** How common? Most common language? Goals/purposes? Proficiency? Feelings? Policies, curriculum.
- **Added later:** Literacy practice definition (daily written language use, values/attitudes); examples.
- **Sources:** Encyclopedia articles, ResearchGate (e.g., second/foreign language learning post-apartheid).

Alternative: Computer Literacy

- **Ideas:** Statistics (homes with computers/Internet); knowledge extent (basic/advanced); school use; focus (society/schools?).
- **Comparisons**: Across socioeconomic levels; employment links.
- **Interviews:** Families, school admins, computer teachers.
- **Sources:** Articles on children's digital practices, unequal homes, basic literacy/earnings.

Example 2: Intro to Islamic Law (Modified)

1-2 page comparative analysis: Criminal law (death penalty) in USA vs. Islam (non-Muslim country focus).

Mind Mapping

- **USA:** Electrocution, lethal injection (cruel/torturous); sentencing varies state-to-state (unfair); examples.
- **Islam:** Beheading (humane, quick); contrasts cruelty.
- **Sources:** US death penalty stats (28 states authorize); Amnesty; Islamic views (Quran-based justice, fiqh).

Example 3: Women's Rights in Islam vs. West

10-15 page comparison; address criticisms.

Brainstorm Ideas

- **Marital rights**, oppression myths.
- **Pre-Islamic** era (low respect) vs. Islam's elevation.
- **Hijab wisdom**; Western dress (past modest, recent changes).
- **Work:** Islam allows; West equates to men's jobs (ignores differences).
- **Roles:** Wife, mother, daughter.
- **Sources:** Islamic sites (Abdurrahman.org, IslamQA); books (e.g., Muhammad Jabali).

Key takeaway -

Pre-writing = foundation of good writing. Always:

- Brainstorm first
- Research next
- Organize finally

Your ideas will grow over time — that's normal

Lecture 14 Writing the Rough Draft, Topic Sentences & Thesis Statements

Writing Process: Step 2 - Rough Draft

What is a rough draft ?

Rough draft is not perfect; expect revisions.

- Focus on idea flow; ignore spelling, word choice, editing.
- Skip lines on paper for later additions.
- Typing allows easy edits.
- Shift from prewriting (words/phrases) to full paragraphs.
- Focus on ideas flowing, not perfection
- Don't edit + write at the same time. Don't worry about:
    - Spelling
    - Grammar
    - Perfect word choice
- Just write freely

Paragraph Basics

Paragraph: 5-10 sentences, 50-200 words, unified around one main idea.

- Contains:
    - Topic sentence (sums up main idea; often first).
    - Supporting details (facts, examples, quotes).
    - Concluding sentence (relates back to topic).

Structure of a Paragraph

Component	Purpose
Topic Sentence	Introduces main idea
Supporting Details	Explain/justify idea
Conclusion Sentence	Wraps up idea

Topic Sentence

- Indicates main point; previews paragraph content.
- Can be anywhere (usually first).

Types of Topic Sentences

1. General Statement - Introduces multiple points.
    - Example idea: "Several factors influence leadership"

2. Evidence-Based Statement -
    - Refers to data/survey/results
    - Leads to explanation of evidence
3. Strong Opinion/Claim
    - Makes a clear assertion
    - Needs explanation + support

Avoid in Topic Sentences

- Obvious facts: “Ottawa is Canada’s capital.”
- Vague opinions: “I think banks overcharge.”

Activity 1: Write Topic Sentences (given by the teacher)

Paragraph Summary	Sample Topic Sentence
1990s memories (Friends, Rachel's haircut, Guess jeans, brings back memories of Sassy magazine)	"Thinking about the 1990s fashion and popular culture."
Ice cream in summer	"Ice cream is my favorite treat on a hot summer day."
Blowing gum bubbles	"It is difficult to blow bubbles with gum."
Making chocolate milk	"Chocolate milk is made in three easy steps"
Naughty dog (toilet paper, trash)	"My dog is really naughty."
Bedtime routine	"Every night, I do the same things before bed."

Activity 2: Identify Topic Sentences (given by the teacher)

Identify Topic Sentence	Topic Sentence
Best family	"The best trip my family ever took was to New Orleans."
Washing utensils	"It is important to completely wash all utensils."
Poetry in songs	"Many people think poetry is old-fashioned.. (focus: poetry is modern).
Growing a garden	"Growing a garden can be fun, good exercise.."
Falling asleep tips	"There are several things you can do to try and fall asleep."

Supporting Details

Definition: Information that supports the topic sentence

Types

- Examples
- Facts
- Statistics
- Reasons
- Explanations
- Quotes

Important Rule: Always include MORE THAN ONE example

Analogy: Topic sentence = roof; supporting details = walls.

Writing a Paragraph (Step-by-Step)

Refer book academic literacy p.79

Method/Steps:

1. Write topic sentence - “The business person I most admire is Richard Branson.”
2. Add Reason 1 - Embodiment of entrepreneurship.
3. Add Reason 2 - Virgin brand spans credit cards to airlines.
4. Add Reason 3 - Boundless energy, passionate, adventurous.
5. Rephrase topic sentence (conclusion) - “Business-wise, there is no stop in Branson.”

Graphic Organizers (Prewriting)

Simple: Topic → Main idea (topic sentence) → Reasons (phrases).

Detailed: Intro → Paragraphs (topic sentence + details) → Conclusion.

Activity - Identify TS and DS - Given by the teacher

Note - underlined is TS, Not Underlined is DS

1. *“Quality of restaurant = food, ambience, service."* "Dark walls create intimacy.”
2. "Daily practice improves proficiency." / "Students benefit from homework 3 ways.”
3. "Useful toolbox essentials." / "Keep 2 screwdrivers.”
4. "Beauty via nutrition, hydration, sleep." / "Body 70% water.”
5. "Kids did paper crafts." / "Children made best of rainy day.”
6. "Chicken is versatile." / "Marinades vary taste.”

Key Rule for Good Paragraphs

- Elaborate your ideas. Don't stop at one example. Expand with:
    - Explanation
    - Illustration
    - Evidence

Thesis Statement

- Introduces main idea of essay; specific topic + subtopics/method.
- Usually last sentence of introduction.
- Functions of Thesis Statement
    - Introduces main topic
    - Shows writer's position
    - May list subtopics
    - Acts as a roadmap

Essay Example: Computer Revolution

Refer book - intro to academic writing p. 116

General intro: Age of technology → new tech.

Narrow: Personal computers influence lives (communication, business).

Thesis: "Personal computers have revolutionized communication and business."

Types of Thesis Statements

Paper Type	Example Thesis
Analytical	"Analysis of college admissions reveals challenge for counselors (high scores vs extracurriculars)."
Expository	"College life: studying, class, socializing."
Argumentative	"High school grads should do community service year for maturity/ awareness."

Thesis Formula (Video)

- Simple Formula
    - Topic + Opinion = Thesis
- Example
    - Topic: Prison overcrowding
    - Opinion: National shame
    - **Thesis: Prison overcrowding is a national shame**

- Roadmaps essay: Predicts supporting points (facts, reasons, problems).

Strong Thesis Checklist

✓ Answers question
✓ Takes challengeable position (not fact/summary)
✓ Specific (avoid vague like "good")
✓ Passes "so what?" test
✓ Essay supports it (revise if not)
✓ Passes "how/why?" test
✓ Gives direction (roadmap)

What Thesis is NOT

1. Title: "Home and Schools" → "Parents ought to participate more."
2. Announcement: "My subject is…" → "Professor X is incompetent."
3. Fact: "Jane Austen wrote Pride and Prejudice."

Bad vs Good thesis

Bad/Poor	Good
"World in terrible mess."	"Trade barriers contribute to int. tensions."
"People too selfish."	"Selfishness worst in rush hours."
"The American Steel industry has	?

Lecture 15 Revising

What is Revising?

- Revising = Re-visiting your writing
- Focus on:
    - Adding / deleting words & sentences
    - Reordering paragraphs
    - Improving ideas

Focus on content, NOT: Spelling, grammar, punctuation
Not rewriting everything; perfecting the draft

When to Revise

- Do NOT revise immediately

- Let writing sit for a few days and return with a fresh perspective
- Avoid revising while drafting—interrupts flow
- Don't rush; plan time: e.g., 7 days drafting (45 min/day), 2-3 days revising

Why Revision is Important

- Helps you:
    - Remove unnecessary or repetitive ideas
    - Fix unclear meaning
    - Improve reader understanding
- Allows you to:
    - Check if writing says what you intended
    - Ensure ideas are clear and meaningful
- Tip: Ask someone else to read your work (They should ask questions, not rewrite it)

Revision Steps

Check Organization and Focus

- Logical order; use rubric to meet requirements
- Topic appropriate? Not too broad/narrow; stay on track (e.g., cigarette smoke ≠ alcohol)
- Thesis honest? Modify if needed; make specific/provocative (not general)

Evaluate Introduction and Purpose

- Clear aims; hooks reader
- Balance sections: Avoid over-detailing trivial points or thinning out later

Verify Support and Flow

- Fulfill thesis promises; support all claims
- Appropriate tone/formality for audience
- Transitions smooth ideas; topic sentences introduce paragraphs
- Rearrange paragraphs if needed

Confirm Information and Conclusion

- Facts accurate/credible; cite sources properly; avoid opinions without evidence
- Conclusion ties together, ends stimulating (not abrupt/redundant)

Practical Revision Tips

- Print copy for easier edits; track changes in Word; skip lines when handwriting
- **Read aloud:** Catch awkwardness, missing ideas, boredom

- **Focus agendas** per draft: Pick 2-3 issues (e.g., organization first)
- **Multiple revisions:** Pros revise many times (e.g., Hemingway: 39x last page)
- **Avoid pitfalls:** Don't "fall in love" with draft; stay open to feedback (get 2+ readers, plan time)
- **Handle contradictions:** Adjust thesis, acknowledge exceptions (don't ignore)

Sentence-Level Revision

- **Read aloud sentence-by-sentence:** Fix stumbles, boredom, vagueness
- Use **forceful verbs** (e.g., "defends" > "argues for")
- **Vary structure:** Avoid repetitive starts (e.g., "She went… She bought…")
- **Cut extras:** Prepositional phrases, "it is/there are"; use thesaurus for precision
- **Descriptive elements:** Adjectives, similes, metaphors, sensory words (esp. narrative)
- **Transitions:** Ensure smooth flow between ideas. Use: Transition words, contrast words

Narrative Writing Checklist

- **Hook** grabs attention
- **Answers**: Who, What, When, Where, Why, How
- **Uses:** Descriptive language (similes/metaphors/strong verbs/emotion/sensory words/dialogue)
- **Has:** Varied sentence structure (add details/examples/descriptions)
- **Ends with:** Transitions; smooth ending; all on-topic

Thesis-Driven Writing Checklist

Check:

✓ Assignment requirements met
✓ Clear structure (Effective intro/thesis, supported body, strong conclusion)
✓ Strong thesis
✓ Evidence supports arguments : Relevant, cited, explained insightfully
✓ Paragraphs = one main idea each; transitions
✓ Sentences: Clear subject/verb, formal, concise, varied
✓ Proper citations: Sources - Integrated, credible, proper format

Sample Rubic Category:

Category	Key Criteria
Introduction	Hook; discusses topic; introduces text/author/ elements; clear thesis with context
Evidence	Seamless quotes; relevant; sophisticated explanation linking to claim
Analysis	Connects to thesis/humanity; explains "why"
Conclusion	Restates thesis differently; ties together